

Content Warning: Contains references to ethnic violence, death, massacres, fire (arson), political instability, and severe trauma, portrayed through a fictional diary of a teenager.

Diary of Aloys Mukeshimana: Childhood in 1959-1964 Rwanda
by Lorelei Kongs

Aloys Mukeshimana is a young boy raised in post-revolutionary Rwanda. His grammar is made to reflect his age, not always being written in the most professional formatting. He often references Hutu and Tutsi people, these are classes primarily distinguished by former Belgian colonialists. Hutu were the less wealthy individuals that made up the majority of the population, while Tutsi were the wealthy minority. This piece is not made to take a political side, but to represent the horrors of violence, especially on younger individuals.

Entry #1: November 18, 1959

Dear future Aloys,

Many Hutu gathered today in revolution. I could sense the violence coming for the past week but I did not expect there to be so many Hutu. My family and I sheltered, hoping to avoid danger. We prayed endlessly to God, but to no avail. The violence continued, but I do thank God for sparing us today. I will pray for tomorrow.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 13

Entry #3: November 28, 1959

Dear future Aloys,

Today I heard the news that the family of someone I used to know has been attacked. His name is Emmanuel. It feels weird to not know what has happened to him. Back when we were close, I always admired him. We often played football together, everybody wanted to be on his team. Emmanuel, I pray you are safe. May God have mercy on your family.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 13

Entry #9: December 23, 1959

Dear future Aloys,

My father took us to the church today in search of safety. They prayed over us, but I'm not sure how much they actually cared. My cousin Yvette fled today, she is going to Burundi. I truly hope she is able to find safety there. Maybe in time we can join her. I'm not sure I'm ready to give up my home yet though. Maybe it will get better and we won't have to.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 13

Entry #15: February 12, 1960

Dear future Aloys,

I have prayed every day. Hutu are only becoming more dangerous. I sympathize with them, I want to understand. I do not understand why they aim to kill us. What could provoke my own people to want to kill us? I hope God will avenge us. I want peace upon Rwanda. I found a newspaper today, they call us Ruanda. In freedom as Rwanda, peace will prevail. Tutsi and Hutu could work together.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 13

Entry #17: February 21, 1960

Dear future Aloys,

There are rumors today that the leaders of our country are failing. I feel like I have been failed daily. I feel that my family has been failed as well. I've been thinking back on Emmanuel, I'm sure he is not the only friend of mine to disappear. I cannot imagine that he may no longer be. I will not put it into existence. I will see him again, once it is safe.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 13

Entry #26: June 4, 1960

Dear future Aloys,

We went to church today. I hoped they would pray over us, maybe God will finally listen and end this. How on Earth could they praise the Hutu for revolutions. How could these men, claiming to be appointed by God, praise those who are killers? To take a life is the most vile sin. What have we done that God and his servants could turn their backs on us so harshly? I feel abandoned by the God who should protect me. Maybe I am confused.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 13

Entry #39: September 2, 1960

Dear future Aloys,

Today is my birthday. I did not get to celebrate as I could last year. Today I thought of Yvette, she must be much happier in Burundi than we are here. I hope she remembered my birthday. She would make me the best Isombe. I miss the food we once had.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 14

Entry #47: November 30, 1960

Dear Aloys,

I watched today as the house of my best friend Jean turned to ash. I did not see his family leave. I do not want to think further. I can still smell the smoke.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 14

Entry #55: February 4, 1961

Dear Aloys,

King Kigeli V Ndahindurwa was overthrown. He led us and cared for our people. With him gone, I fear for my safety. The safety of all of my people is at stake. The Hutu will kill us.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 14

Entry #71: July 9, 1961

Dear Aloys,

For the first time in months we visited the church. It is weird to leave my home, only my home feels safe. The church seems to support Hutu. The church leaders even said we must pray for the new leaders of Rwanda. Does God hate us?

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 14

Entry #97: December 25, 1961

Dear Aloys,

It is Christmas. I was not able to receive gifts. I miss the days of celebrating holidays. I feel selfish to miss this while I am blessed to be alive. I miss Yvette. I miss Jean. I miss my life before.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 15

Entry #126: July 1, 1962

Dear Aloys,

Today, Rwanda is free. We have gained our independence. I would dream of this day for so long, why now does it feel so dreadful? I fear that this will give freedom for Hutu to attack. I will try to be hopeful, maybe the Hutu will now see that we can all prosper in freedom.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 15

Entry #141: October 17, 1962

Dear Aloys,

God has given freedom to Rwanda but it feels like a curse. These new leaders do not serve me or my people. I fear for my life fully now. I do not have hope this will get better. I try to pray but it feels empty. I'm holding onto the maybe but I feel it slipping away.

- Aloys Mukeshimana, 16

Entry #204: December 21, 1963

Dear Aloys,

I heard that some Tutsi exiles are trying to come back. I wonder if I will see Yvette again. Maybe this is a sign that things will improve. Hopefully Hutu will see the struggle we have been through and sympathize. I believe I would sympathize with us. Do they not see the pain we face?
- Aloys Mukeshimana, 17

Entry #211: January 13, 1964

Dear self,

There are massacres against my people. God has failed us. I do not have hope for tomorrow.
- AM, 17

Entry #213: January 27, 1964

Dear self,

I watched them set fire to buildings today. I am sure that people I know have been hurt. Soon it will be my family. I do not understand why.
- AM, 17

Entry #214: February 3, 1964

Dear,

I can hear the rampage outside. There are shouts and screams constantly. I can smell the smoke of homes nearby. I think now is my time.
- AM, 17.